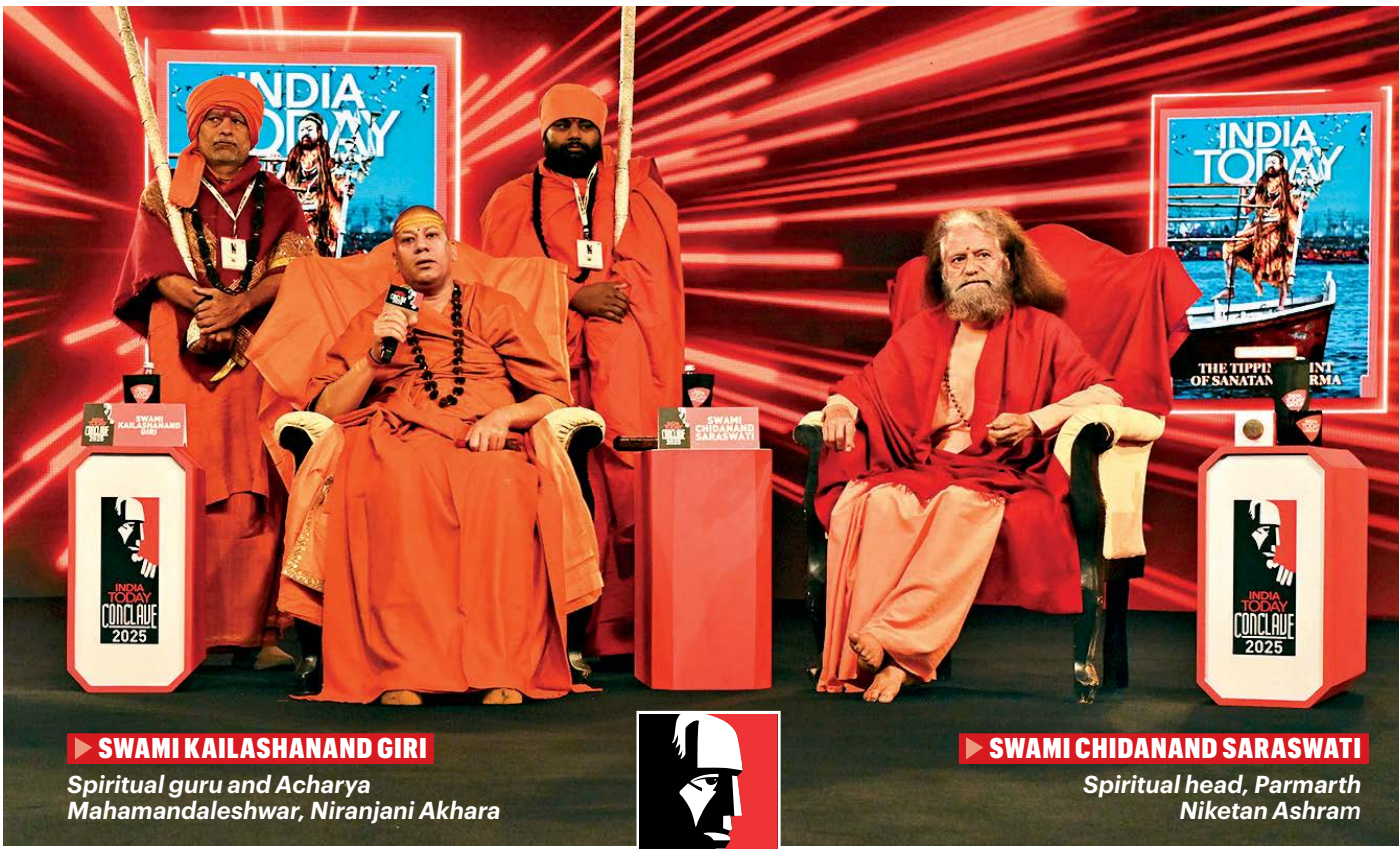


SWAMI KAILASHANAND GIRI
Spiritual guru and Acharya Mahamandaleshwar, Niranjani Akhara

SWAMI CHIDANAND SARASWATI
Spiritual head, Parmarth Niketan Ashram

ARUN KUMAR

MAHAKUMBH THE TIPPING POINT OF SANATAN DHARMA

A SELF, NOT A SELFIE, MOMENT

The recently concluded Mahakumbh, despite setbacks like the tragic stampede that claimed at least 30 lives near the Sangam, has emerged as a pivotal moment for Sanatan Dharma. As one of the largest religious gatherings globally, it has sparked unprecedented interest, reinforcing its significance beyond a spiritual congregation.

At the India Today Conclave, spiritual leaders Swami Kailashanand Giri and Swami Chidanand Saraswati discussed how the Mahakumbh is reshaping perceptions of Sanatan Dharma, a term that has been (inadequately) translated as 'eternal law' and has become synonymous with Hinduism. Swami Kailashanand emphasised its historical and spiritual significance, pointing to the growing interest of foreigners in Sanatan practices. "When foreigners see lakhs of sadhus taking a dip for purification, they feel a connection and want to be part of this experience. The Ganga not only grants *moksha*, but first offers knowledge, then detachment, then devotion and, ultimately, salvation," he said. He also revealed that Apple founder Steve Jobs's widow Laurene Powell Jobs, whom he had named 'Kamala' after giving her *diksha*, had shared her experience with tech mogul Elon Musk, who apparently expressed interest in attending his spiritual camp.

> **Who doesn't need peace and spirituality? Sanatan is the only faith that carries a message of peace, inclusion, and harmony**
> –Swami Kailashanand Giri

> **You can wear jeans but don't forget your genes. You can get new cars but don't forget your sanskars (values)**
> –Swami Chidanand Saraswati

Swami Chidanand spoke about the Kumbh's transformation over the years and the unity it fosters. "Some came in private jets, while others walked barefoot, but there was no division—only unity," he said. He highlighted the peaceful coexistence of different communities in Prayagraj, citing its 267 mosques and 22 per cent Muslim population, and shared that not a single incident of violence was reported despite nearly 670 million people attending the Mahakumbh. The spiritual leader also addressed concerns that youth engagement with Sanatan Dharma is superficial and driven by social media trends. "This is not a selfie moment, it is a self moment," he said, urging the younger generation to embrace their roots while adopting modernity. ■